

Lecture 2 – How to make a good presentation

UCL-ELEC0054 – MSc Projects

Today's menu

Class outline

1. Housekeeping
2. What is the presentation?
 1. Assessment requirements
 2. Format
3. How to make a good presentation:
 1. Narrative
 2. Communication
 3. Advices



1. Housekeeping

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Risk Assessment

- Every project must have a **risk assessment** — including desk-based work
- Where to find the form:
 - Moodle → Templates → Risk assessment template
- Where to submit:
 - Moodle → Submission centre → Risk assessment
- I know **Moodle** is **not cooperating** this year. Please **have your risk assessment ready ANYWAY**.
- I will follow up with instructions to bypass Moodle

2. What is the presentation?

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Assessment requirements

What is the presentation assessment?

- Duration: **10 min** presentation + **5 min Q&A**
- Weight: **10%** of the module grade
- ⚠ **You MUST** pass the presentation to pass the module
 - Minimum passing grade: 50 / 100
 - 49 in the presentation = FAIL — even with 90 in the dissertation
- Panel: 2 academics from a different research field (non-specialists)
- Date: Friday, 12 June 2026

FAQs

What is the presentation assessment?

- ***Can I do the presentation online?***

No, presentations must be in person.

- ***10 minutes for the presentation are not enough. Can I have more?***

No, you cannot have more. The assessment is designed like this to push you to synthesise your work and explain it in a very easy way

- ***Can I defer my presentation assessment with a DAP?***

In theory yes. In practice, **no**. The presentation day is designed to mimic a conference day, where students can go around panels, have coffee breaks, network, and present their work.

Format

What is the presentation assessment?

- Your presentation must follow this structure with 6 slides:
 1. **Area of research** — what's the research areas?
 2. **Problem** — what problem are you solving? Why is it an obstacle today? What's holding us back from solving it?
 3. **Significance** — why does it matter to solve it? Why not solving another problem?
 4. **State of the Art** — what already exists? What are your “rivals” in solving the problem?
 5. **Hypothesis** — what is your approach? Describe your hypothesis. What do you think it is true or false that you would like to prove?
 6. **Plan** — how will you execute it? What experiments do you plan to run? Will they provide enough evidence?
 7. **Risk Analysis** — what could go wrong? What if an experiment proves the hypothesis wrong? What if you don't have the budget to run experiments? What if the second experiment depends on the first, but the first failed?

3. How to make a good presentation?

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Narrative

How to make a good presentation

Your research is a **story** — guide the audience through it

- **Area:** “I study the ability of machines to perform sequential decision making”
- **Problem:** “While recent methods got a lot of success, they still struggle with...”
- **Significance:** “Should we solve the issue, machines would be able to solve more complex problems...”
- **SOTA:** “The best performing methods that try to solve the problem, but they still fail (explain why) are ...”
- **Idea/Hypothesis:** “I think that using high-level, abstract actions, instead of low level, physical ones, the performance of the models would get better in these scenarios...”
- **Plan:** “I plan to test my hypothesis with the following experiments, and I expect the following evidence..”
- **Risk analysis:** “My experiments rely on having a good computing infrastructure. If that is not available, I will alternatively do this...”
- Each slide = one beat of the story. Do not skip ahead.

Communication

How to make a good presentation

- Your panel are not experts in your field — speak accordingly
- The golden rule: explain as if your audience is 5 years old
 - If a 5-year-old would not follow it → it is too technical
- One idea per slide — do not crowd it
- No walls of text — use short bullets and simple visuals
- Speak to the audience, not to the screen
- You will NOT be penalised for being too simple
- You WILL be penalised for being too technical

Tips & Advice

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- Know your opening sentence by heart
- Practise out loud at least twice — time yourself
- Use diagrams: figures speak louder than words
- Prepare 2–3 answers for likely Q&A questions
- Leave out: too complex equations, code, pseudocode, jargon, benchmark tables
- Keep in: real-world impact, plain-English analogy, clear timeline, key risks
- If in doubt about a detail → leave it out

Bad examples

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- Let's have a look at bad presentations from last year and what to avoid

